

FIRST SPACE TOURIST



ON APRIL 28, 2001, DENNIS TITO of Santa Monica, California, became the first person to enter space on a trip paid for out of his own pocket. The space tourist, whose fare for a journey to the International Space Station and back was reputed to be \$20 million, lifted off from the launch pad at Baikonur, Kazakhstan, on board a Soyuz-TM rocketcraft.

Tito had originally hoped to pay to visit the Mir space station, but when that prospect evaporated in 2000, his ambitions shifted to the ISS. The Russian space authorities, eager for cash from any direction, saw no problem in fulfilling Tito's dream. NASA, by contrast, was openly hostile, but unable to block the trip. Tito was evidently delighted with his experience of eight days in space. On his return he described himself as "a serious man who had a dream and pursued it in the face of great difficulty."

In May 2002, South African Mark Shuttleworth became the Russians' second paying passenger. Five more individuals made paid passages to the ISS before Russia suspended space tourism in 2010.

next waymark was the arrival of the first three-person crew to begin the permanent occupation of the ISS in October 2000.

As the demanding schedule of flights and spacewalks went forward, the ISS was justly described as the most extraordinary construction site in existence. But the cost of the ISS program naturally continued to escalate from an originally agreed \$17 billion. Estimates were soon putting the eventual price at between \$50 billion and \$100 billion. And cost was not the worst of the ISS's problems. On February 1, 2003, the Shuttle program suffered its second fatal accident when *Columbia* broke up

on reentry, and its crew of seven were killed. An investigation revealed that foam broken off the main propellant tank on lift-off had struck the leading edge of *Columbia*'s left wing, damaging the reinforced carbon panels that protected against the extreme

temperatures experienced during re-entry. All remaining Shuttles were grounded while safety issues were addressed. It was not until July 2005 that flights resumed with the launch of *Discovery* on mission STS-114, but even then the problems continued. Foam was again shed at launch. Although this time no damage was caused to the

orbiter, Shuttle flights were again suspended while the problem was fixed. The ISS project stumbled forward in the absence of the Shuttle. Russian Soyuz and Progress spacecraft delivering supplies were able to keep a crew of two in residence on the space station and limited construction work continued. But only the

Shuttle had the cargo capacity to carry major components of the ISS.

In the immediate aftermath of the loss of *Columbia*, President George W. Bush had hastened to assure the world that the future of the human

"I spent 60 years on Earth
and I spent 8 days in
space. From my viewpoint,
it was two separate lives."

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VENTURESTAR

Intended as the next step on from the Space Shuttle, the Lockheed Martin X-33 VentureStar was to be a fully reusable space vehicle – essentially an aircraft that could fly into space and back. Begun in the late 1990s, the project soon ran into apparently insuperable difficulties and was cancelled in 2001.

